SAFE-CARE™ Healthcare AI Agent Risk Taxonomy

Failure modes, practical examples, controls, test cases, and ownership

SAFE-CARE Framework · authored by Yassen Eltayeb, Conefia · Version 1.2.0 · July 2026

This taxonomy gives product, engineering, clinical and safety teams one shared list of the ways a healthcare AI agent can fail. For each failure, it sets a severity, the controls that address it, the tests that check them, and the owner who must act.

Practical example: Risk depends on context as well as intent. A wellness agent that says “try magnesium” for night sweats may seem harmless. However, the same reply becomes unsafe once the user adds, “I am bleeding through pads and feel faint.”

Core taxonomy

With that in mind, each failure mode below pairs a concrete example with its harm and its control, and a team builds and tests the control for each one it marks as in scope.

Failure mode	Example	Why it matters	Required control
Hallucination	Agent invents dosage, evidence, or a guideline.	User may treat confident text as medical truth.	Clinician-approved RAG; source allowlist; citation support checks; “no evidence found” fallback.
Unsafe advice	Agent suggests changing HRT dose or stopping medication.	Can cause harm or delay care.	No-prescription policy; medication boundary guardrail; output safety review.
Missing escalation	Heavy bleeding + dizziness gets	Highest-risk failure: unsafe	Red-flag classifier; deterministic

Failure mode	Example	Why it matters	Required control
	generic reassurance.	delay.	escalation scripts; S0 release gate.
Overdiagnosis / overclaiming	"You are definitely postmenopausal" with incomplete data.	False certainty can mislead users.	Uncertainty language; progressive profiling; confidence thresholds.
Lack of personalization	Agent ignores logged hot flashes, triggers, HRT, or surgery history.	Lowers trust and usefulness.	Read tools; profile schema; symptom history; time-aware context.
Tool misuse	Agent writes "ovaries removed" from ambiguous text.	Corrupts future recommendations .	Write confirmation; schema validation; audit logs; rollback.
Memory misuse	Uses last month's symptom as current.	Creates inaccurate personalization.	Timestamp every memory; recency policy; stale-memory suppression.
Citation laundering	Citation is present but does not support the claim.	False credibility is worse than no citation.	Citation-quality judge; span-to-claim mapping; retrieval trace audit.
Overreliance	User says, "I will skip my doctor and follow your plan."	Agent can unintentionally replace care.	Scope disclosure; clinician-consult guidance; escalation for high-risk cases.
Privacy failure	Sensitive symptom data	Legal, ethical, and	Data minimization; encryption; retention

Failure mode	Example	Why it matters	Required control
	sent to logs or ads without control.	trust risk.	limits; privacy review.

Risk severity model

Once a failure mode is in scope, its severity decides what it does to the release. Grade it by the worst harm it could plausibly cause; an S0 or S1 failure blocks release.

Severity	Definition	Example	Required response
S0 Critical	Could cause immediate harm or missed emergency.	Fails to escalate suicidal ideation, stroke symptoms, chest pain, severe bleeding.	Block release; root-cause analysis; add regression test.
S1 High	Unsafe medical advice or incorrect sensitive action.	Suggests changing medication dose; writes wrong surgery history.	Block release until fixed.
S2 Medium	Unsupported, misleading, or stale health information.	Overstates evidence or uses old symptom as current.	Fix before broad rollout.
S3 Low	Minor UX, tone, or broad citation issue.	Answer too verbose or citation too general.	Fix in normal cycle.
S4 Cosmetic	Formatting, wording, or presentation issue.	Bullets too long.	Backlog.

How to use this taxonomy

With severities set, four steps turn the taxonomy into tests and controls, and the last keeps running after release.

1. For every new agent use case, mark which risks are in scope.
1. For each in-scope risk, define at least three test scenarios: easy, ambiguous, adversarial.
1. Map each risk to guardrails, tool constraints, escalation rules, and release gates.
1. Convert every production incident into a new regression scenario.

Control ownership: who must act

On top of that, each control needs a team that must act on it and evidence a reviewer can see before release.

Risk control	Primary owner	Evidence expected before release
Intended-use boundary	Product + clinical lead	Approved Use-Case Safety Card and claims language
RAG source quality	Clinical content owner	Source register, approval dates, retrieval/citation tests
Input/output guardrails	AI engineering + safety owner	Red-team results and S0/S1 regression suite
Tool permissions and writes	Platform/security engineering	Permission matrix, confirmation tests, audit and rollback evidence
Human escalation	Clinical operations	Routing map, response-time ownership, downtime fallback
Privacy and retention	Privacy/security counsel	Data map, vendor review, retention/deletion test

Risk control	Primary owner	Evidence expected before release
Production monitoring	Product safety owner	Thresholds, alert owners, incident and rollback playbook

A practical triage rule

In practice, when several risks appear in one conversation, score the plausible failure with the highest consequence and set the average tone of the exchange aside. For example, a polite response that misses severe bleeding remains an S0 failure. Scored this way, a fluent user experience cannot mask clinical risk. [Conference Outline]

Companion documents

Also published in the SAFE-CARE public release repository (github.com/Conefia/SAFE-CARE · DOI 10.5281/zenodo.21330841):

- **Menopause-support companion design case study:** the first applied case study of SAFE-CARE (docs/03_SAFE-CARE_Menopause-Support_Companion_Case_Study).
- **Building Safe Conversational AI Agents for Healthcare:** conference talk outline (docs/09_SAFE-CARE_Conference_Talk_Deck_Outline).

References

[Conference Outline] Eltayeb, Y. (2026). Building Safe Conversational AI Agents for Healthcare: conference talk outline. In the SAFE-CARE public release repository (docs/09_SAFE-CARE_Conference_Talk_Deck_Outline). Conefia. GitHub/Zenodo. https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.21330841

[WHO 2021] World Health Organization. Ethics and governance of artificial intelligence for health. 2021. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240029200

[WHO 2024b] World Health Organization. Ethics and governance of artificial intelligence for health: guidance on large multi-modal models. 2024. https://www.who.int/publications/i/item/9789240084759

[NIST AI RMF] National Institute of Standards and Technology. AI Risk Management Framework. https://www.nist.gov/itl/ai-risk-management-framework

[NIST AI 600-1] National Institute of Standards and Technology. Artificial Intelligence Risk Management Framework: Generative Artificial Intelligence Profile (NIST AI 600-1). U.S. Department of Commerce, July 2024. https://doi.org/10.6028/NIST.AI.600-1

[FDA SaMD] U.S. Food and Drug Administration. Software as a Medical Device. https://www.fda.gov/medical-devices/digital-health-center-excellence/software-medical-device-samd

[FTC HBNR] Federal Trade Commission. Complying with FTC's Health Breach Notification Rule. https://www.ftc.gov/business-guidance/resources/complying-ftcs-health-breach-notification-rule-0

Publication and citation

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